MODULE 3 WORKSHEET

The Silent Advantage
Yes, No and Pause Planner

Use this worksheet before and after a negotiation. It takes 15–20 minutes. Fill in the parts that help; skip the rest.

Conversation I'm preparing for: _____ **Date:** _____

01 Yes audit

List the "yeses" you already have in this deal or project. Which type is each one, and how will you test it?

THE YES I RECEIVED (WHO, WHAT)	TYPE	SIGNALS I NOTICED / QUESTION TO TEST IT
	Counterfeit · Confirmation · Commitment	
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Warning signs of a counterfeit yes: said quickly or too smoothly · enthusiasm that doesn't match body language · no follow-up questions · a history of agreeing but not delivering · vague answers when asked for details.

02 Commitment questions

Script the three steps you will use to turn a yes into a commitment.

1 · Follow-up question ("What specific actions are we agreeing to take moving forward?")

2 · Probe for hesitation ("You seem unsure. Can we address any concerns?")

3 · Small, immediate action that tests the agreement (meeting, PO, letter of intent, draft)

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03 No-oriented question builder

Write the yes-questions you would normally ask in this conversation, then reframe each one so that "no" is the safe answer.

INSTEAD OF…	ASK…
"Is this a good time?"	"Have I caught you at a bad time?"
"Can you approve this today?"	"Is it out of the question to wrap this up today?"

Starters: "Would it be ridiculous to…?" · "Would it be a bad idea to…?" · "Is it out of the question if…?" · "Would it be crazy to consider…?" · "Is there something here that doesn't sit right with you?" **Check:** can they genuinely say no without looking foolish?

04 Handling "no" script

Which "no" are you most likely to hear? Prepare your response before you need it.

The "no" I expect to hear:

TECHNIQUE	MY WORDS
1 · Open-ended question "What are your main concerns?"	
2 · Validation + strategic empathy "I understand why…" · "It sounds like…"	
3 · Reframe the "no" positively "It sounds like we're getting closer to what's really important to you…"	

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05 Pause plan

Choose where you will use silence deliberately. Mark the pauses you will practise and write the moment for each.

✓	PAUSE	WHEN I'LL USE IT IN THIS CONVERSATION
☐	**1 · Before speaking** Reflect, slow down, signal calm	
☐	**2 · After speaking** Let my key point land	
☐	**3 · After asking** Invite a deeper answer	
☐	**4 · To encourage elaboration** Verbal mirror + pause	
☐	**5 · While listening** Nod, stay quiet, don't shift focus	
☐	**6 · To shift tone** "Let's slow down for a second."	

My key point, the one I will follow with silence:

My most important question, the one I will not rescue with a second question:

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06 After-action review

Fill this in within 24 hours of the conversation.

QUESTION	WHAT HAPPENED
Which yeses did I get, and which type was each?	
Did I test them with specifics? What did the answers reveal?	
Which no-oriented question did I use, and what did the "no" uncover (clarification, correction, commitment)?	
When I heard a "no", did I ask before I answered?	
Which pause did I hold? What came out of the silence?	
Where did I fill a silence I should have left alone?	

Agreed next steps (what, who, by when):

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